

Who They Are

Made in God's image, loved by the Father, gifted for the whole family's benefit

BIG IDEA

We honor skeptics because they are children of God like us. Their skepticism does not change who God made them to be and how much they are needed in his family.

OPENING

Someone you know

Write the name or initials of someone you know who doubts or rejects the Christian faith. What is one thing about them you admire?

BEFORE WE BEGIN

This isn't a game

Why Mary's Assumption Is Indefensible (opening remarks)

Gavin Ortland · 1:54–3:09

Before critiquing a belief others hold dear (other Christians, in this case), Protestant scholar Gavin Ortland stops to talk about what it feels like to be on the receiving end and shares the Schaeffer quote below.

LISTEN FOR

- Why he says defending the faith is not a game
- How love handles the job of speaking in a way that might “knock someone over”

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=skuBFLns8WA&t=114s>



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THE QUOTE IN THE CLIP

Not a game

“I need to remind myself constantly that this is not a game I am playing. If I begin to enjoy it as a kind of intellectual exercise, then I am cruel and can expect no real spiritual results. As I push the man off his false balance, he must be able to feel that I care for him. Otherwise I will only end up destroying him, and the cruelty and ugliness of it all will destroy me as well. ... Pushing him towards the logic of his presuppositions is going to cause him pain; therefore, I must not push any further than I need to.”

— Francis A. Schaeffer, *The God Who Is There* (1968), in *The Francis A. Schaeffer Trilogy* (Crossway, 1990), 138

Think it over

1. Schaeffer says the other person “must be able to *feel* that I care for him.” What makes someone feel cared for, or not, in a conversation about faith?
2. How do you figure out how much pain in a conversation is “necessary” or “unavoidable”? What advice or models can you think of to help with this?

WHO THEY ARE · 1

Made in God’s image

Genesis 1:26–27

Genesis 9:6

Psalm 8:3–8

James 3:9–10

LISTEN

“I intend to treat them like that”

Why This Oxford Mathematician is Confident God Exists

John Lennox · Alex O'Connor · 1:20:12–1:22:13

Oxford mathematician John Lennox, in conversation with skeptic Alex O'Connor, remembers growing up in Northern Ireland during the Troubles, when his own family suffered bombing.

LISTEN FOR

- What his father said when Lennox asked why he took the risk
- What Lennox says that answer taught him to do

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3gKCwldMZS8&t=4812s>



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WHO THEY ARE · 2

Loved by the Father

Matthew 5:44–45

John 3:16

1 Timothy 2:3–4

Jonah 4:10–11

WHO THEY ARE · 3

Gifted before they believe

Genesis 4:20–22

Exodus 18:13–24

1 Kings 5:1–12

Isaiah 45:1

LISTEN

Before the debate

Alex O'Connor & Glen Scrivener: Morality, Freedom, Slavery & the Bible (Uncommon Ground)

Glen Scrivener · Justin Brierley · 3:46–4:35

Before a long debate with skeptic Alex O'Connor, evangelist Glen Scrivener is asked what he thinks of the man he is about to disagree with.

LISTEN FOR

- The gifts Scrivener sees in O'Connor

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-ZnVNM8lkGw&t=226s>



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Talk it over

1. Image, love, gifts: which is easiest for you to forget when you're talking with a skeptic? Why?
2. What gifts have you seen in non-believers you know? Has God used any of them in your own life?
3. James says we bless God and curse people made in his likeness *with the same tongue*. Where have you seen that happen, online or in person?

THEN COMES THE COMMAND

Honor everyone

1 Peter 2:17

1 Peter 3:15–16

2 Timothy 2:24–26

LISTEN

“I love you. Thank you.”

Breaking Down Walls: A Christian and an Atheist in Conversation

Drew (Genetically Modified Skeptic) and Sean McDowell · Sean McDowell · 41:33–45:43

Atheist YouTuber Drew has just described how Christians treated him after he shared his doubts. Sean McDowell responds, then asks Drew for advice.

LISTEN FOR

- What McDowell says first, before he asks anything
- Drew’s three steps for a parent whose child is doubting
- How McDowell receives the advice

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=VJX28I54YxE&t=2493s>



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One guardrail

Honoring someone as God’s image-bearer doesn’t mean that all truth is relative (“your truth” vs. “my truth,” etc.). It also doesn’t mean that skeptics don’t need to hear about Christ. We honor them because we know who they are, who they are made to be. They are worthy of honor as precious and beloved members of the family, even if estranged. Every member of this family needs every other one. That’s how God designed us.

So, we tell them about Christ. Knowing Christ as we do, how could we not? Being gentle in discussion about faith, truth and eternity isn’t weakness in evangelism. Prioritizing a listening ear isn’t about giving up on sharing the most important story that has ever been told by a human tongue. It is showing the same love and patience that God showed to all of us by sending his Son to sit with us in our suffering. God’s Word in human flesh didn’t just preach. He connected. He sympathized. He healed.

THIS WEEK

Practice

1. Pray by name for the person you thought of at the start of class.
2. Thank God for one specific gift you see in them.
3. If it fits naturally, tell them something you genuinely appreciate about them.



Watch the clips and see every lesson online:

honortheskeptic.stlctrufant.com

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